The Restless Soul in Three Phases of Movement Resulting from Sin

"You stir man to take pleasure in praising you, because you have made us for yourself, and our heart is restless until it rests in you."[1] With this proclamation, Augustine ends the first paragraph of *Confessions* and lays the foundation for the rest of his book: humanity, made in the image of God, is restless in its pursuits until ultimately recognizing God as the true goal of this movement. Although God's original putting of humanity into motion was, before the Fall, rightly ordered toward God through praise, it became corrupted into restlessness because of the Fall as disordered motion, turned away from God as sin. Augustine provides this template in Book VII, writing: "…Wickedness is…a perversity of will twisted away from the highest substance, you O God, toward inferior things…" (126). Indeed, he repeatedly declares that we find rest only in God because, in all things we seek - joy, peace, love, etc. - only God, who is "the Good, in need of no other good" (304), endlessly embodies and generates that which we seek and find in praise. This paper will address this restlessness of the soul as Augustine writes in his own account, arguing that the soul's restlessness is the product of sin and not inherent to creation, and is sated not in ending movement altogether, but in directing it appropriately back toward God via praise. To demonstrate the forms this restlessness takes, Augustine employs a diverse language of movement. This restlessness, communicated through its various forms, thus entails three distinct forms of movement: external into the material world away from God, inward into the self and blinded by sin, and, finally, beginning to turn away from sin, upward toward God. Ultimately, this movement concludes with giving one's restlessness back over and unto God entirely.

[1] Augustine, *Confessions*, trans. Henry Chadwick, Oxford World's Classics (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008), 3. Subsequent citations provided parenthetically in text.

The first type of movement this restlessness takes on is entirely disordered, oriented externally away from God and into pursuits wholly foreign to the Holy. Reflecting on his time at Carthage and Rome, Augustine recalls ways in which society and others may fall victim to their own movements away from God, recounting activities such as theatrical plays, gladiatorial games, etc., noting specifically his own captivity to the theatrical shows he attended. Even in these generally passive activities, his language takes on active determinations, describing Alypius at the gladiatorial spectacle as he "drank in savagery" and "took the madness home with him" (101). Using the language of movement in his own personal restlessness, Augustine deploys verbs signifying his movement into his two primary categories of emptiness away from God – lust and Manichaeism.

Augustine's lust is indeed a recurring theme throughout *Confessions,* and his language to articulate the forms it takes is myriad. In Book II, recounting his adolescence, he begins the action of moving away from God by describing how he "ran wild in the shadowy jungle of erotic adventures" (24). In his struggles, Augustine's words describe that which is not an internal state but an outward movement, further delineating the sinful origins of his restlessness away from God: "submerging…in a whirlpool of vice" (24), "rush[ing] headlong into love" (35), "roll[ing] in its dung" (28), etc. Ending Book VI, Augustine describes the tortuous movements of lust found in the body, twisting and contorting, which can find relief only in God (110).

Beyond Augustine's sexual pursuits away from God, he details his religious movement toward Manichaeism, as he "fell in with men proud of their slick talk" and "wandered far away, separate from you [God]" (40). Even as he describes what is traditionally understood to be an inward life in religious seeking, Augustine employs an outward, active vocabulary, believing God to be a physical entity to be understood primarily through the senses, one in which he

sought through his "lacerated and bloody soul" (59) in his body. As he details his Manichean beliefs, he begins to recognize a rightly oriented calling toward God, yet he is still disordered in his seeking, which he describes as "traveling," albeit "away from the truth" (43). Reflecting on his time spent with the Manichees, Augustine notes the futility of his seeking of God in the external world: "You seek the happy life in the region of death; it is not there" (58). To be sure, it is not that creation itself is evil nor the cause of the soul's restlessness; rather, Augustine argues that evil is the absence of good and actually nothingness, that is, the "privation of the good" (43). He writes, more specifically, that one will not find God in the external world, but only more death. It is thus only through his subsequent exposure to the philosophers that he recognizes the disorder of his external movements, which compels him to turn inward, acknowledging that "by the Platonic books [he] was admonished to return into [him]self" (123).

Everywhere Augustine turned in the external world, he encountered neither rest nor respite in his pursuits, but rather further lack and further restlessness, the result of the sin of a continually disordered orientation. In his transition from the external world to the inner world, outward movement is transformed into an inward motion. While he no longer sought to find rest in the external material world, he remained restless in his internal actions. This turning of face was not sudden or unforeseen; even earlier in his life, in his exposure to *Hortensius*, Augustine desired to turn away from the world and "fly back to [God]" (39); at this point, though, he had not yet extinguished the siren call of the world. However, even as Augustine declares his eventual mastery of the external world (e.g., no longer beholden to it), he, "in [his] arrogance…rose against you and ran up against the Lord" (120). Thus, as he matured, his inward transition began to acquire a language of inner movement deployed primarily through his eyes, which he laments were closed due to sin through his "swelling conceit" (120). Indeed, his sight

was set on himself, not God. For example, Augustine writes, quoting 1 Peter 5:5, that it was because of his pride that God rejected him: that even as he turned to God inwardly, he was not yet prepared to receive God (121). Augustine describes this disordered movement both as the attracting force of God and the repelling force of himself in resistance: "…because I did not wish to observe myself…you set me before my face so that I should see how vile I was" (144).

As Augustine devoted himself to rhetoric, philosophy, and teaching, he was accosted by new forms of resistance in the sins of pride and arrogance. The obstacles against which Augustine's movements found themselves rebuffed were found internally; he writes that even while Platonism offered him the knowledge and world of ideas he now sought, it did not offer him the respite of a rightly ordered and active movement. He recognized instead the restlessness of his soul to be satisfied in Christ alone, quoting the Gospel of Matthew, "Come to me, you who labor" (131). Thus, Augustine's eyes, becoming rightfully reordered and ultimately relocated into his heart (152), mark the definitive conversion and change to its final form of movement.

Dramatically, the key moment in Augustine's conversion story, found in Book VIII and heard as the refrains from children, echoes the need for upward movement, though subtly stated in the calls of "Pick up and read, pick up and read" (152). Even in these small voices, the reference to an upward movement is maintained: he is told to "Pick *up* and read," not simply and neutrally *go* and read. This upward trajectory is mirrored moments later in his own standing up and rushing to read the Bible, orienting himself away from sin and toward God. Indeed, recognizing that his restlessness continued beyond his movement inward, Augustine notes the call to move upward and ascend toward God, supported by the impending death of Monica. The potency of Augustine's acknowledgement is intense and found most dynamically in his recollection of the vision at Ostia: "Step by step we ascended even further…into our own minds.

We moved up beyond them so as to attain the region of inexhaustible abundance where you feed Israel eternally with truth…" (171). After his years of philosophy and exploring the inner workings of his mind, Augustine fully realizes the power of the mind when rightly aimed toward the higher – God – away from the sin of using it as a means for itself. He reflects on the power of memory and recall, investigating and reviewing his life, and remarks on his "transcending" and "climbing up through [his] mind," "pass[ing] beyond" it to God who is "constant above [him]" (194). He yields his reliance on his own power to move him, submitting entirely to God to lift him up and away from sin, beyond his own mind; humbled before God, Augustine relies on "Your Word, eternal truth" to "raise those submissive to him to himself" (128).

Here, Augustine confronts his own sins and submits himself to God. He is no longer master of his world; indeed, he is not master of any world. In accepting this, he finds his own self-motivated and self-actuated movement is fruitless, being the result of sin; he requires the infinite, sustaining movement of God to carry him to Godself. In this final recognition of the futility of his own movement, Augustine understands the goal his soul has been seeking; it is not, however, the soul itself at rest, but rightly ordered, away from sin: resting in the infinite movement of God. Even in the last pages of Book II, Augustine foretells this infinite movement as praise, writing that those who seek will find, and who find will praise, recalling from Matthew 25:21, "The person who enters into [God] 'enters into the joy of the Lord'" (34). Indeed, this rest is not passive but active through the act of praising, being lifted and carried into God through God's own dynamic participation.

In conclusion, writing about his restlessness of soul throughout *Confessions,* Augustine deploys an active and dynamic language of movement. He uses this language to describe the forms his restlessness, propelled by the result of sin, takes on. First, he sought satisfaction in the

external world; next, he moved inward into his mind. Then, ultimately, corrected and ordered appropriately, he aimed upwards toward God and submitted to God to sustain that movement for him. This sin, contrary to the Manichean belief in the wickedness of materiality, is not inherent in being created, but results from humanity's turn from God in the Fall. Augustine's word choice throughout *Confessions* demonstrates the many actions his restless soul took, building a vocabulary meant to draw the reader into the fatigue such striving inflicts on a person. Recounting his life and its various stages, his words offer a warning to the spiritual reader: seek rest not in the world nor in the sinful and vain pursuits of mental and philosophical mastery, but rather submit your restlessness to God, order it appropriately, and find true rest in praising God. As Augustine writes in the final pages: "But you, Lord are always working and always at rest…Your movement is not in time, and your rest is not in time" (304). Finally, after a lifetime of seeking and battling with a restless soul, Augustine concludes that it is not in stillness that his soul finds respite, but in the active rest of praising God, free from sin.

Bibliography

Augustine. *Confessions*. Translated by Henry Chadwick. Oxford World's Classics. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008.